



Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) - CLN-003

Sharps & Clinical Waste Disposal

Purpose

To ensure the safe handling, segregation and disposal of sharps and clinical waste in accordance with UK legislation, infection prevention standards, and Save Face requirements, protecting staff, clients and the environment.

Scope

This procedure applies to all staff working within the clinic who handle clinical waste or use sharps during treatments.

Responsibilities

All staff are responsible for:

- Following this SOP at all times.
- Disposing of waste into the correct waste stream.
- Reporting damaged sharps bins, spillages or incidents immediately.
- Completing incident reporting following any sharps injury.

The Clinic Manager is responsible for ensuring:

- Appropriate waste containers are available.
- Clinical waste collections are arranged with the licensed waste contractor.
- Staff receive appropriate training.

Procedure

1. Sharps Disposal

Immediately after use:

- Dispose of needles, cannulas, blades and other sharps directly into an approved yellow sharps container.
- Never recap, bend or manipulate needles before disposal.
- Dispose of sharps immediately after treatment at the point of use.
- Do not pass exposed sharps between staff where avoidable.
- Never leave sharps unattended.

Sharps bins must:

- Remain upright at all times.
- Be located close to treatment areas.
- Never be filled beyond the manufacturer's fill line.
- Be securely locked when full.
- Be labelled with the date assembled and date closed (if required by supplier).

Once sealed, sharps containers must be stored safely until collection by the approved waste contractor.

2. Clinical Waste Disposal

The following items should be disposed of as clinical waste where appropriate:

- Blood-contaminated gauze
- Cotton pads
- Gloves contaminated with blood or bodily fluids
- Treatment couch roll with significant contamination
- Used dressings
- Other contaminated disposable materials

Clinical waste must be placed into the designated clinical waste bin using the appropriate colour-coded waste bag supplied by the waste contractor.

Waste bags should never be overfilled and must be securely tied before collection.

3. General Waste

Non-contaminated items such as:

- Paper towels
- Packaging
- Cardboard
- Food waste
- Office waste

should be disposed of in the general waste or recycling bins where appropriate.

4. Spillages

If blood or body fluid contamination occurs:

- Wear appropriate PPE.
- Clean immediately using approved disinfectant products.
- Dispose of cleaning materials as clinical waste.
- Wash hands thoroughly afterwards.

5. Sharps Injury Procedure

In the event of a sharps injury:

1. Encourage the wound to bleed gently.
2. Wash thoroughly with soap and running water.
3. Do not scrub the wound.
4. Cover with a waterproof dressing.
5. Inform the Clinic Manager immediately.
6. Complete an incident report.
7. Seek urgent occupational health or medical advice regarding post-exposure assessment if required.

PPE Requirements

Where appropriate staff should wear:

- Disposable nitrile gloves
- Disposable apron (if contamination risk exists)
- Eye protection if splash risk is present